

Kiss of the Vampire

film poster

(1963)

**AS Component 1:
Investigating the Media**
**A Level Component 1: Media
Products, Industries and Audiences**

**Focus area:
Media language
Representation
Media contexts**

PRODUCT CONTEXT

- Produced by Hammer Film Productions and distributed by J. Arthur Rank and Universal, *Kiss of the Vampire* was intended to be the second sequel to 1958's *Dracula*, although the film's script actually makes no reference to Stoker's character. This is perhaps to distance itself from unfavourable comparisons to the superior Christopher Lee who starred in the original film.
- In addition to *Dracula*, Hammer had, by 1963, success with other 'monster movie' franchises such as *The Mummy* and *Frankenstein*. Distributors Universal also saw early success with films in this genre.
- Historically, 1963 saw the early stages of 'Beatlemania' and the so-called 'swinging sixties', the assassination of JFK and the Soviet Union launching the first woman into space.

PART 1: STARTING POINTS – Media language

Cultural context:

The 1960s **audience** for this advert could be assumed to be familiar with the **codes and conventions** of 'monster movie' film posters – such as its **composition, fonts and representations** of 'the monster' and its (usually female) victims. Interesting **intertexts** for comparative study might include:

The Evil of Frankenstein (1964)
<http://www.imdb.com/title/tt0058073/mediaviewer/rm2054095104>

Blood From The Mummy's Tomb (1971)
<http://www.imdb.com/title/tt0068290/mediaviewer/rm892444416>

Consider codes and conventions, and how media language influences meaning:

- The capitalised, **serif font** of the title creates **connotations** linked to the vampire film **genre** with its 'wooden' styling (referencing the vampire's coffin or the stake needed to kill him perhaps) and the blood dripping from the letter V's 'fang.'
- The use of a 'painted' main image is highly **conventional** of films of the period and links to the poster for Christopher Lee's *Dracula*, but the fact that it's in colour (**anchored** by the text "In Eastman Color") **connotes** that this is a modern telling of an older story.
- The gloomy grey, black and brown **colour palette** reinforces the film's dark, scary **conventions** while the red highlight colour draws attention to the attacking bats, the vampire and the blood – all key **visual signifiers** for the genre.
- Conventionally**, the stars are listed with the more highly paid male actors first and in order of fame, Clifford Evans having starred in Hammer's 1961 hit *Curse of the Werewolf*.

Consider theoretical perspectives

Semiotics – Roland Barthes

- Suspense is created through the **enigmas** surrounding the **connoted** relationship between the male and female vampires (emphasised by the "kiss" of the title) and the fate of their two victims (**Barthes' Hermeneutic Code**).
- Barthes' Semantic Code** could be applied to images of the bats and their conventional